The History of Indian Cinema

Introduction

Indian cinema is the largest film industry in the world by number of films produced, making roughly 1,500 to 2,000 feature films a year in more than 20 languages, and selling billions of tickets. It includes Hindi cinema, popularly called Bollywood, based in Mumbai, and strong regional industries: Tamil cinema (Kollywood, centred on Kodambakkam in Chennai), Telugu (Tollywood), Malayalam, Kannada, Bengali, Marathi, Punjabi and others. Cinema in India is a major source of entertainment, culture, politics and national identity, and many film stars have become political leaders, especially in Tamil Nadu.

Beginnings

Moving pictures reached India within months of their invention. On 7 July 1896, the Lumiere brothers' films were shown at Watson's Hotel in Bombay, only six months after their first show in Paris. Harishchandra Sakharam Bhatavdekar shot short films in 1897 to 1899. In 1913 the first full-length Indian feature film appeared.

What Was India's First Full-Length Feature Film?

India's first full-length feature film was "Raja Harishchandra", released on 3 May 1913 at the Coronation Cinematograph in Bombay. It was a silent film, about 40 minutes long, based on the legend of the truthful King Harishchandra from Indian mythology, and it was directed, produced and written by Dhundiraj Govind Phalke, known as Dadasaheb Phalke. Phalke made it after being inspired by seeing the film "The Life of Christ" in 1910, and made the film with his own resources, with his wife Saraswatibai helping behind the scenes. As women were unwilling to act in films at the time, male actors played female roles; the female role in this film was played by a man, Anna Salunke.

Who Is Called the Father of Indian Cinema?

Dadasaheb Phalke (1870 to 1944) is called the Father of Indian Cinema. Between 1913 and 1937 he directed about 95 films and 26 short films, including "Mohini Bhasmasur" (1913), in which Kamlabai Gokhale became the first Indian actress, "Lanka Dahan" (1917) and "Kaliya Mardan" (1919). In his honour, the Government of India instituted the Dadasaheb Phalke Award in 1969, India's highest award in cinema, and the first recipient was the actress Devika Rani.

The Coming of Sound

The first Indian sound film, or talkie, was "Alam Ara", directed by Ardeshir Irani and released on 14 March 1931 in Bombay, a Hindi-Urdu film with songs. It was a huge success and began the tradition of songs and music in Indian films. Soon talkies were made in Tamil, Telugu, Bengali and other languages. The 1930s and 1940s saw the growth of big studios such as Bombay Talkies, Prabhat and New Theatres, and social films on themes such as caste and women's rights.

When Did Tamil Cinema Begin?

Tamil cinema began in 1916 with "Keechaka Vadham" (The Destruction of Keechaka), the first Tamil silent film, directed by R. Nataraja Mudaliar, who set up the first South Indian film studio, India Film Company, in Madras. It was based on an episode of the Mahabharata. The first Tamil talkie was "Kalidas", released on 31 October 1931, directed by H. M. Reddy, which, in a unique way, had Tamil, Telugu and Hindi dialogue. Tamil cinema grew rapidly in the 1930s to 1950s with the support of studios in Madras such as Gemini Studios, AVM Productions (founded by A. V. Meiyappan, which began in Chennai in 1945), Vijaya Vauhini and Modern Theatres in Salem. Early stars included M. K. Thyagaraja Bhagavathar, whose "Haridas" (1944) ran for three years, and P. U. Chinnappa. The 1950s and 1960s are known as the golden age of Tamil cinema, with the great actors Sivaji Ganesan, "Nadigar Thilagam", and M. G. Ramachandran (MGR), who became Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu in 1977, along with Gemini Ganesan, S. S. Rajendran and heroines such as Savitri, Padmini, Vyjayanthimala and B. Saroja Devi. Writers such as C. N. Annadurai and M. Karunanidhi used film scripts to spread the ideas of the Dravidian movement, and both became Chief Ministers. Later stars include Rajinikanth, Kamal Haasan, Vijay, Ajith Kumar, Suriya, Dhanush and directors such as K. Balachander, Bharathiraja, Mani Ratnam, Shankar, and the composers Ilaiyaraaja and A. R. Rahman. Chennai's Kodambakkam is the heart of the industry, giving the name Kollywood. Tamil Nadu has more than 1,000 cinema screens, and the Chennai International Film Festival is held every December.

Golden Age of Hindi and Parallel Cinema

After independence, the 1950s are the golden age of Hindi cinema, with directors such as Raj Kapoor, Guru Dutt, Bimal Roy and Mehboob Khan, and "Mother India" (1957), which was nominated for an Oscar. Satyajit Ray from Bengal launched the "parallel cinema" or art film movement with "Pather Panchali" (1955), which won awards at Cannes, and he received an honorary Academy Award in 1992, and the Bharat Ratna. Other masters are Ritwik Ghatak, Mrinal Sen, Adoor Gopalakrishnan, Shyam Benegal and Girish Kasaravalli. The 1970s saw "Sholay" (1975) and Amitabh Bachchan, the "angry young man". Later superstars such as Shah Rukh Khan, Aamir Khan and Salman Khan were popular in the 1990s.

Modern Era and Global Recognition

The 21st century brought multiplexes, digital cinema, streaming platforms like Netflix and Amazon Prime, and "pan-Indian" films, in which a film in one language is released in many languages, including "Baahubali" (2015), "KGF", "RRR" (2022), "Pushpa" and "Ponniyin Selvan". Indian films now earn from the global market. A. R. Rahman, from Chennai, won two Academy Awards in 2009 for the music of "Slumdog Millionaire". "Naatu Naatu" from "RRR", composed by M. M. Keeravani, won the Academy Award for Best Original Song in March 2023. "The Elephant Whisperers", a Tamil-language documentary short about an elephant caregiver couple in the Nilgiris, directed by Kartiki Gonsalves and produced by Guneet Monga, won the Oscar for Best Documentary Short in 2023. Satyajit Ray, Bhanu Athaiya (who won the first Indian Oscar in 1983 for costume design on "Gandhi") and Resul Pookutty are other Indian Oscar winners.

Institutions and Awards

The Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) certifies films, with categories U, UA, A and S. The National Film Awards, started in 1954, are given for the best films of the year. The Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) in Pune and the Madras Film Institute, now the MGR Government Film and Television Institute at Taramani in Chennai, train filmmakers. The National Film Archive of India is in Pune.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include piracy, the rising cost of films, censorship disputes and the competition from streaming platforms. The future may bring AI-assisted filmmaking, virtual production and more regional content for the world.

Quick Facts

- India's first full-length feature film was "Raja Harishchandra" (1913) by Dadasaheb Phalke.
- Dadasaheb Phalke is called the Father of Indian Cinema.
- Tamil cinema began in 1916 with the silent film "Keechaka Vadham"; the first Tamil talkie was "Kalidas" (1931).
- India's first talkie was "Alam Ara" (1931).
- "Naatu Naatu" from RRR won the Oscar for Best Original Song in 2023.